

The Morning Briefing

SAN ANTONIO, TEXAS

THURSDAY, JULY 30, 2026 — POLITICS, LAW, FAITH & THE WORLD

MARCUS JOHNSON

LEDE — BREAKING OVERNIGHT

US Resumes Airstrikes on Iran in “Powerful Response” to Attacks on American Forces

US Central Command confirmed early Thursday that it renewed strikes on Iran after Iranian forces attempted attacks on American bases in the Middle East a day earlier, breaking the halt in hostilities President Trump had declared over the weekend at Tehran’s own request. It is the second collapse of a US-Iran de-escalation in a month, and the first time Iran has struck directly at US forces rather than regional or Israeli targets since the latest round of fighting began.

US POLITICS

Senate Judiciary Postpones Vote on Blanche for Attorney General

The Senate Judiciary Committee postponed Thursday’s scheduled vote to advance Todd Blanche’s nomination as attorney general after Sens. John Cornyn (R-TX) and Thom Tillis (R-NC) declined to commit their support. Their concern centers on a Justice Department settlement of President Trump’s lawsuit against the IRS, a provision of which shields Trump and others from audits and enforcement on tax returns filed before the settlement. Cornyn canceled a second meeting with Blanche this week, saying the department had not clarified the audit-shield language he asked about.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is a rare case of Senate Republicans publicly slow-walking a Trump nominee over a self-dealing concern rather than ideology. Whether it holds past the next committee session is worth watching.

CNN — cnn.com/2026/07/29/politics/todd-blanche-nomination-cornyn

Congress Forces Release of Epstein Files

Congress passed a bipartisan bill requiring the Justice Department to release its files on Jeffrey Epstein within 30 days, with redactions permitted to protect survivors’ personal information or shield active investigations. The House vote was 427 to 1; Rep. Clay Higgins (R-LA) cast the lone dissenting vote.

NBC News — nbcnews.com/politics/congress/house-bill-force-release-epstein-files-bipartisan-vote-rcna244301

Clayton Confirmed as Intelligence Director; Musk Ramps Up Midterm Spending

The Senate confirmed Walter Clayton of New York as Director of National Intelligence. Separately, Elon Musk’s America PAC is reportedly ramping up a major midterm investment — door-knocking, digital ads, and mail — aimed at holding the House and Senate majorities for President Trump.

Congress.gov — congress.gov/congressional-record

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Shadow Docket Keeps Growing Even in Recess

The Supreme Court is now in its summer recess, but its expanded use of the emergency “shadow docket” this term has drawn fresh scrutiny in recent weeks. Without full briefing or signed opinions, the justices halted a California policy barring teachers from notifying parents about a student’s transgender status, and separately blocked a New York state court order that would have forced the redrawing of a congressional district.

WHY IT MATTERS

The sheer volume of unsigned, unexplained emergency rulings this term is itself a story that legal analysts across the ideological spectrum are now flagging, regardless of how they view the underlying merits.

U.S. News & World Report — usnews.com/news/politics/articles/2026-07-02/us-supreme-court-supercharges-its-shadow-docket-dividing-the-justices

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Netanyahu Courts Washington Ahead of October Election

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu spent Monday through Wednesday in Washington, meeting President Trump and members of Congress just under three months before Israel's October 27 election. Sen. Tom Cotton (R-AR) told him Israel has been "the best ally we've had since Great Britain in World War II." Sen. John Fetterman (D-PA), meeting Netanyahu separately, called New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani "worthless" over his criticism of the Israeli leader.

ANALYTICAL READ

Treat the senators' remarks as domestic political theater for their own electorates, not assessments of the war. Netanyahu's trip lands exactly when he needs to be seen at home as Washington's preferred partner, heading into a vote widely framed as a referendum on his wars in Gaza, Lebanon, and Iran. The optics serve him more than they describe conditions on the ground.

The Times of Israel — [timesofisrael.com/liveblog-entry/2026-07-30-2026](https://timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/2026-07-30-2026)

Opposition Blocks Coalition Funds for Settlements, Haredi Schools

Israel's opposition blocked roughly \$116 million in coalition funds earmarked mostly for Haredi education and West Bank settlements, including about \$22.4 million for programs tied to "hilltop youth" outposts, via an eleven-hour Knesset Finance Committee filibuster. The money is now unlikely to move before the election.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is coalition patronage spending timed to an election, not routine budgeting — and it sits on top of a separate \$431 million the security cabinet already committed in June to new West Bank settlements, a fact easy to lose inside the Iran-war coverage.

The Times of Israel — timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/opposition-blocks-transfer-of-nis-392-million-in-coalition-funds-for-haredi-schools-settlements

Record \$58.6B Patriot Contract Signals Strained US Stockpiles

The US Army awarded Lockheed Martin a record \$58.6 billion, seven-year contract for Patriot interceptor missiles, converting a one-year, \$4.7 billion deal from April into a multiyear procurement plan, with the Army citing depleted stockpiles from operations across multiple fronts including Iran.

ANALYTICAL READ

This is the clearest dollar figure yet on what sustained backing of Israel's regional campaigns, plus direct US-Iran strikes, is costing American war-reserve capacity — an interest-divergence marker worth tracking against Israeli officials' public framing of the conflict as manageable.

The Times of Israel — timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/us-awards-lockheed-martin-a-record-58-6b-contract-to-produce-patriot-missile-interceptors

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Leo XIV Meets Marx and Fernandez as Munich Blessings Dispute Comes to a Head

Pope Leo XIV received Cardinal Reinhard Marx, Archbishop of Munich and Freising, and Cardinal Victor Manuel Fernandez, Prefect of the Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith, in separate audiences Wednesday — five days after 26 priests of Munich-Freising sent Marx a letter questioning his plan to implement diocesan guidelines permitting blessings for same-sex and other "irregular" couples. The priests argue the guidelines go beyond 2023's *Fiducia supplicans* declaration and contradict Church teaching on marriage. Marx has proposed a one-year pilot; the signatories say they will appeal directly to the Holy See if unsatisfied. The Holy See Press Office did not disclose what was discussed in either audience.

WHY IT MATTERS

Fernandez's own dicastery warned German bishops in a November 2024 letter, made public only in May, that "unions cannot be legitimized with blessings." And returning from his Africa trip in April, Leo XIV said directly that the Holy See "does not agree with the formalized blessing of couples," warning the practice "can cause more division than unity" — a direct papal rebuke of the Munich approach that this week's audiences suggest is now coming to a head.

Also received in audience Wednesday: Msgr. Giordano Piccinotti, president of the Administration of the Patrimony of the Apostolic See; Alessandro Cassinis Righini, Auditor General of the Holy See; and Sr. Alessandra Smerilli, Prefect of the Dicastery for the Service of Integral Human Development, accompanied by Cardinal Fabio Baggio.

InfoVaticana — infovaticana.com/en/2026/07/29/leo-xiv-resumes-audiences-with-the-main-economic-and-doctrinal-leaders-of-the-curia

WORLD NEWS

Azerbaijan Bans Iranian State Outlets

Azerbaijan banned two Iranian state outlets, Sahar TV and the Mehr News Agency, after Iran's Intelligence Ministry labeled Azerbaijani state broadcaster AzTV "enemy media." It is a small but real sign of Iran's confrontation with the US and its neighbors spilling into the South Caucasus.

The Times of Israel — timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/azerbaijan-bans-two-iranian-news-outlets-after-tehran-brands-its-state-tv-enemy-media

Chabad HQ Car-Ramming Suspect Sentenced to Time Served

The man who rammed a car into Chabad's world headquarters in Brooklyn in January was sentenced to time served (six months) plus \$19,000 restitution. The judge found he was seeking to connect with his own Jewish heritage and had mental health problems rather than hatred toward Jews, and criticized the Justice Department for seeking a harsher sentence.

The Times of Israel — timesofisrael.com/liveblog_entry/man-who-rammed-car-into-nycs-chabad-headquarters-sentenced-to-time-served

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Factional Warfare Explains the Iran Whiplash

"One Battle After Another: Factional Struggles and the Making of Trump's Foreign Policy," a European Council on Foreign Relations policy brief, maps the fight inside Trump's coalition between "restrainers" who want the focus kept on the homeland, "prioritisers" who want it on the Indo-Pacific, and the sidelined old-guard hawks. It traces how that unresolved factional struggle, not a settled doctrine, has produced the whiplash of outreach-then-strikes defining current Iran policy — and directly explains why last night's resumed strikes look less like strategy and more like an unstable coalition improvising in real time.

ECFR — ecfr.eu/publication/one-battle-after-another-factional-struggles-and-the-making-of-trumps-foreign-policy

The Traditional-Doctrine Case Against the Munich Guidelines

"From Satan to the Sanction: What's Wrong with Fiducia Supplicans" (Crisis Magazine), alongside Cardinal Gerhard Muller's essay charging the declaration is internally self-contradictory and Fr. Thomas Weinandy's argument that blessing couples in irregular unions "without giving the impression that the Church is not validating their sexual activity is a charade," together lay out the traditional-doctrine case against the Munich guidelines now sitting on Pope Leo XIV's desk.

Crisis Magazine — crisismagazine.com/opinion/from-satan-to-the-sanction-whats-wrong-with-fiducia-supplicans